

6 Learning

6.1 Class Notes

- Neutral stimulus = no response
- Unconditioned stimulus = unconditioned response
- Pavlov = dogs, watson = people, skinner = operant conditioning (reward / punish), Bandura = observation

6.2 Study Guide Material

Aversive conditioning is an aspect of operant conditioning that deals with unpleasant stimuli and how we learn to stay away from them. Escape is defined as performing an operant response to cause an aversive stimulus to cease (ex. run to the other side of a shuttle box to get away from shock).

Observational learning occurs when an organism's response is influenced by the observation of others, who are called models.

Positive reinforcement occurs when a response is strengthened because it is followed by the presentation of a rewarding stimulus.

Responses can be strengthened either by presenting positive reinforcers or by removing negative reinforcers.

John Watson is referred to as the 'father of modern behaviorism' and was influenced by Pavlov's work. Classical conditioning can be broken down into two basic parts – acquisition and extinction. Acquisition is the initial stage of learning something – like Pavlov's dog learning to drool at the tone of the bell. The graph here shows the strength of the dog's response, measured in

drops of saliva, to the conditioned stimulus (the bell).

Extinction is the process by which the association between the unconditioned stimulus (meat powder) and conditioned stimulus (bell ringing) is broken.

Spontaneous recovery is an extinguished conditioned stimulus suddenly elicits a conditioned response again.

Aversive conditioning is an aspect of operant conditioning that deals with unpleasant stimuli and how we learn to stay away from them.

Intermittent reinforcement , or partial reinforcement, occurs when a designated response is reinforced only some of the time.

Unconditioned stimulus no stimulus without conditioning (US). Conditioned response a learned reaction from previous conditioning (CR).

Acquisition is the initial stage of learning a new response. Skinner's principle of reinforcement holds that organisms tend to repeat those responses that are followed by favorable consequences, or reinforcement. Something is positively reinforcing if individuals are reinforced when it is presented to them, like food, water, sleep, or sex.

Operant conditioning is a form of learning in which responses come to be controlled by their consequences.

6.3 Book Notes

TABLE 6.1 Comparison of Basic Processes in Classical and Operant Conditioning

Process and Definition	Description in Classical Conditioning	Description in Operant Conditioning
Acquisition: The initial stage of learning	CS and US are paired, gradually resulting in CR.	Responding gradually increases because of reinforcement, possibly through shaping.
Extinction: The gradual weakening and disappearance of a conditioned response tendency	CS is presented alone until it no longer elicits CR.	Responding gradually slows and stops after reinforcement is terminated.
Stimulus generalization: An organism's responding to stimuli other than the original stimulus used in conditioning	CR is elicited by new stimulus that resembles original CS.	Responding increases in the presence of new stimulus that resembles original discriminative stimulus.
Stimulus discrimination: An organism's lack of response to stimuli that are similar to the original stimulus used in conditioning	CR is not elicited by new stimulus that resembles original CS	Responding does not increase in the presence of new stimulus that resembles original discriminative stimulus.

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